

Monitoring during labor

Throughout labor, your baby's heartbeat and your contractions will be monitored to make sure that your labor is progressing as it should be and that you and your baby are healthy.

Your baby's heart rate is an indication of how well they are dealing with labor, and it is monitored at regular intervals, called intermittent auscultation. If there are no initial concerns about the baby, monitoring at regular intervals will be continued. However, if a problem is found or you have a high-risk pregnancy (including if you have diabetes, preeclampsia, or are being induced), then you may be advised to have fetal electronic monitoring in order to spot any concerns with your baby's oxygen level. With electronic fetal monitor, your baby's heart rate and your contractions are monitored continuously by an [electronic fetal heart monitor](#). All the information about your labor is recorded on a chart, called a [labor graph](#).

Intermittent monitoring

This is done using a handheld battery-operated device known as a Doppler sonicaid, which is held against your abdomen to listen to your baby's heartbeat. When you are pushing in the second stage of labor, the fetal heart needs to be monitored more frequently. If the heart rate increases or a slowing of the heart rate is heard after a contraction, this may indicate that the baby is starting to have a problem. At this point, continuous electronic fetal monitoring may be recommended to confirm your baby's well-being.

Electronic fetal monitoring

In this type of fetal monitoring, two devices monitor your baby's heart rate and the strength and frequency of contractions. Your baby's heart rate is monitored with a circular ultrasound-like device. If you want, you can hear the heartbeat, or ask that the volume be turned down if this is distracting. Your contractions are monitored with a small plastic circular device. One or two elastic belts are placed around your abdomen to secure the monitors. You should be able to stand, sit, or squat with the monitors in place, and some hospitals have monitors that allow you to walk around and be monitored by radio signal. Your heart rate may also be continuously monitored, particularly if there is a problem differentiating between your heart rate and the baby's heart rate.

Scalp electrode A small electrode is passed through the cervix and attached to the baby's scalp to detect the electrical impulses of their heart. A wire from the electrode comes out via the cervix and attaches to the CTG machine. The electrode is placed